

Editorial

The Blog As Your Voice

LIKE THE POLAR bear that hibernates for extended periods of time, one of India's best-written blogs was in hiding for a year. It re-emerged mid-January, and Indian media professionals are secretly celebrating.

Sadly, though, for all our intellectual and technical superiority, there are few Indian blogs worth a mention. Rajesh Jain's views on emerging technologies—emergic.org—is probably India's best blog across all categories; and Pradyuman Maheshwari's aforementioned brutal take on the Indian media—mediaah.com—comes quite close.

Both Jain and Maheshwari are just two of a breed of what is now a sunrise sector on the Web. At last count, LiveJournal, one of the Web's most popular blogging tool, had nearly 6 million registrations, of which 2.5 million are active. Various studies on the Net mention a disputable, but believable figure: a new blog is created every 7.4 seconds. In the recently concluded US presidential elections, several bloggers were given media status by the government, and some blogs were as keenly followed by the voting public as were CNN.com or Fox TV network.

Here is the bitter truth about blogs, though: They just do not have the reach of a top-notch television channel, nor do they have the clout of a high-selling newspaper. Yet, like the independent aspirant in the elections who is sure not to win, but is an irritant to big-party candidates, blogs will make life a bit uneasy for existing media players.

Because, more than anything else, the blog is a release. Against urban angst; to propagate knowledge; to say the things you always wanted to say, but did not know where to publish, or worse, did not have anyone who would agree to publish.

Columnist Om Malik writes in *Business 2.0*, a respected US-based business and tech magazine: "We are seeing the rise of a new news network, thanks in large part to technology. Average Joes and Janes are now armed to the teeth with technology that can capture and distribute news almost anywhere."

He could not have put it more succinctly.

With blogs, the Web has finally delivered on its promise—to create an alternate social structure; one where an individual makes as much an impact as a



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multi-core media behemoth. What holds bigger promise is that traditional media, despite the fact that they use technology in every possible way to shore up their core competence areas, are averse to investing monies in new avenues, either out of ignorance or out of apathy.

This is the baggage bloggers do not carry.

It is this that will make the blog Your Voice.

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